

Gonzalo Arrieta

CONTACT

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ACADEMIC POSITIONS

Postdoctoral Researcher, Department of Economics, University of Zurich 2024 –

EDUCATION

Stanford University

Ph.D. in Economics

2024

Committee: Muriel Niederle, B. Douglas Bernheim, Alvin Roth

Universidad de Montevideo

Diploma in Economics

2017

B.S. in Economics

2015

REFERENCES

[Muriel Niederle](#)

Dept. of Economics,
Stanford University
niederle@stanford.edu

[B. Douglas Bernheim](#)

Dept. of Economics,
Stanford University
bernheim@stanford.edu

[Alvin Roth](#)

Dept. of Economics,
Stanford University
alroth@stanford.edu

[Kirby Nielsen](#)

Div. of the Humanities and Social Sciences,
California Institute of Technology
kirby@caltech.edu

RESEARCH INTERESTS

Behavioral Economics, Experimental Economics, Cognitive Economics
Welfare Economics, Public Economics

WORKING PAPERS

“Procedural Decision-Making in the Face of Complexity” with Kirby Nielsen

Revising for the Quarterly Journal of Economics (Reject & Resubmit)

A large body of work documents that complexity affects individuals’ choices, but the literature has remained mostly agnostic about why. We provide direct evidence that individuals use fundamentally different choice processes for complex and simple decisions. We hypothesize that individuals resort to “procedures”—cognitively simpler choice processes that we characterize as being easier to describe to another person—as the complexity of the decision environment increases. We test our hypothesis using two experiments, one with choices over lotteries and one with choices over charities. We exogenously vary the complexity of the decision environment and measure the descriptibility of choice processes by how well another individual can replicate the decision-maker’s choices given the decision-maker’s description of how they chose. We find strong support for our hypothesis: Both of our experiments show that individuals’ choice processes are more describable in complex choice environments, which we interpret as evidence that decision-making becomes more procedural as complexity increases. We show that procedural decision-makers choose more consistently and exhibit fewer dominance violations, though we remain agnostic about the causal effect of procedures on decision quality. Additional secondary evidence suggests that procedural decision-making is a choice simplification that reduces the cognitive costs of decision-making.

“What You Don’t Know May Hurt You: Preferences Over Mental And External States” with Lukas Bolte

Revising for the Journal of the European Economic Association

The dominant approach to welfare, revealed preference, is restricted to settings where the individual knows their preferences have been fulfilled. We use a choosing-for-others framework to experimentally study welfare when what the individual believes differs from what is actually true. 42% of participants see welfare as independent of beliefs; 22% see welfare as exclusively determined by beliefs; and 29% care about both beliefs and reality. Furthermore, the average participant values accurate beliefs. While there is large heterogeneity, our results suggest most people support the idea that welfare goes beyond beliefs, which can inform media regulation, informational policies, and government communication. We illustrate how our results inform welfare analysis that jointly considers reality and beliefs by revisiting the welfare effects of biased subjective expectations in a quantitative life-cycle model.

“Failures of Contingent Reasoning in Screening Decisions” with Maxim Bakhtin

Resubmitted to Experimental Economics

Screening decisions—choosing a costly action that reveals valuable information about an unknown quality—can be crucial in various situations, such as hiring workers, selling insurance, or designing policies. If a policy encourages uniform behavior, different people behave similarly, which makes learning about them from their behavior impossible. Choosing whether to screen can be difficult because it requires recognizing and trading off the benefits of information with the costs of getting it. We investigate whether people solve this trade-off correctly and what causes their mistakes. We design an online experiment that simulates a hiring scenario with an initial trial task. Participants make two decisions: first, they select a trial task, which can reveal candidates’ quality at a small cost, and then choose which candidate to hire. We show that most participants choose the dominated task that does not reveal the candidates’ quality, and this mistake persists even with experience and feedback. We test for the mechanisms and show that insufficient screening is driven by failures to anticipate inference and plan the full strategy.

PUBLISHED PAPERS

“Caring to Work or Working to Care: The Intra-Family Dynamics of Health Shocks”
with Gina Li

American Journal of Health Economics 9(2), 175-204, 2023

SELECTED WORK IN PROGRESS

“The Demand and Supply of Paternalism in Financial Planning” with Sandro Ambuehl, Bjoern Bartling, and B. Douglas Bernheim

“The Welfare Costs of False Beliefs” with B. Douglas Bernheim and Lukas Bolte

“Procedural Paternalism” with Muriel Niederle and Kirby Nielsen

REFEREING

American Economic Review, Journal of Political Economy, Journal of the European Economic Association, American Economic Journal: Microeconomics, Journal of Political Economy: Microeconomics, Science Advances, Experimental Economics, Journal of Health Economics, Labour Economics

RELEVANT POSITIONS

Department of Economics, Stanford University

Research Assistant for Muriel Niederle 2022 – 2023

Stanford Economics Research Laboratory (SERL), Manager 2021 – 2022

Research Assistant for Muriel Niederle 2020 – 2021

Research Assistant for Douglas Bernheim 2018 – 2020

Department of Economics, Universidad de Montevideo

Research Assistant for Alejandro Cid and José María Cabrera 2014 – 2015

Research Assistant at Center for Research in Applied Economics 2013 – 2014

TEACHING EXPERIENCE	Department of Economics, Stanford University	
	Teaching Assistant for Muriel Niederle, Econ 179 (Experimental)	Winter 2019
	Department of Economics, Universidad de Montevideo	
	Lecturer (Intermediate Macro)	2017
	Teaching Assistant for Fernando Borraz (Econometrics)	2016
AWARDS & FELLOWSHIPS	Teaching Assistant for Ignacio Presno (International Trade)	2014
	Teaching Assistant for Danilo Trupkin (International Trade, Intermediate Macro)	2013 – 2014
	Leonard W. Ely and Shirley R. Ely Fellowship, SIEPR	2023 – 2024
	Stanford Center for American Democracy Graduate Student Fellow	2020 – 2021
	McCoy Family Center for Ethics in Society Graduate Student Fellow	2020 – 2021
RESEARCH GRANTS	ANII - Agencia Nacional de Investigación e Innovación (uruguayan NSF)	2014 – 2015
	Excellence Scholarship, Universidad de Montevideo	2011 – 2015
	GRC Short Grant, University of Zurich (CHF 5,000)	2026
	Graduate Research Opportunities Fund, Stanford University (\$5,000)	2022
	George P. Shultz Dissertation Fund, Stanford University (\$6,810)	2020
PROFESSIONAL ACTIVITIES	IRiSS Center for American Democracy, Stanford University (\$2,000)	2020
	IRiSS Research Data Grants, Stanford University (\$1,500)	2020
	Department of Economics, University of Zurich	
	AI + Econ Workshop Co-organizer	2026 –
	Behavioral and Experimental Faculty Seminar Organizer	2024 –
INVITED TALKS AND CONFERENCE PRESENTATIONS	Department of Economics, Stanford University	
	Behavioral and Experimental Faculty Seminar Organizer	2021 – 2023
	Behavioral and Experimental Student Workshop Organizer	2019 – 2021
	Helsinki GSE, RUD (Milan), D-TEA (Paris), Riederau Ammersee Workshop (scheduled), AIE Summer Institute - Chicago Booth (scheduled)	2026
	UZH Neuroeconomics, “Rules, Norms, and Complexity” Workshop (Durham, UK), Berlin Behavioral Economics Seminar, CREST (Paris), “Text as Data in Behavioral Economics” Workshop (Potsdam, GER), ECBE (Bergen, NO), TIBER (Tilburg, NL), Matterhorn Symposium (Brig, CH), ZWEP (Zurich).	2025
OTHER	LACEA LAMES (Uruguay), ZWEP (Zurich), University of Zurich, FAIR NHH (Bergen), SITE Psychology (Stanford); ECBE (Bonn); BRIC-X (Venice), BDRM (Chicago), Esade Workshop in B&E Econ. (Barcelona), Stanford Digital Economy Lab, RIDGE LACEA BRAIN (Chile), LIPNE Lab (University of Cambridge), UBC (Vancouver), NYU Abu Dhabi (virtually)	2024
	NABE TEC (Santa Clara), Universidad de Montevideo (virtually), BUE-EBEL (vir- tually); IIPF (Logan, UT); SITE Experimental (Stanford); M-BEES/M-BEPS (Maas- tricht); BABEEW (San Jose)	2023
	Citizenship: Italian, Uruguayan	
	Languages: Spanish (native); English (fluent); Portuguese (intermediate)	

Last updated: June 2026